

Discerning the Sacred from the Secular

(1 Corinthians 11:23-32)

“For I received from the Lord what I also passed on to you, that the Lord Jesus on the night in which he was betrayed took bread, and after he had given thanks he broke it and said, “This is my body, which is for you. Do this in remembrance of me.” In the same way, he also took the cup after supper, saying, “This cup is the new covenant in my blood. Do this, every time you drink it, in remembrance of me.” For every time you eat this bread and drink the cup, you proclaim the Lord’s death until he comes. For this reason, whoever eats the bread or drinks the cup of the Lord in an unworthy manner will be guilty of the body and blood of the Lord. A person should examine himself first, and in this way let him eat the bread and drink of the cup. For the one who eats and drinks without careful regard for the body eats and drinks judgment against himself. That is why many of you are weak and sick, and quite a few are dead. But if we examined ourselves, we would not be judged. But when we are judged by the Lord, we are disciplined so that we may not be condemned with the world.”

In 1 Corinthians 11, Paul warned the church because they had lost sight of the sacred nature of Communion. What God intended as a remembrance of Christ's sacrifice had become a common meal. They treated something holy as ordinary. As a result, Paul warned that God's discipline had come upon some of them because they failed to discern the significance of what they were doing.

As we prepare our minds and hearts for Communion, I want us to consider a simple question:

Will we interpret the Bible through the lens of culture, or will we interpret culture through the lens of the Bible?

We live in a world that often blurs the line between what is sacred and what is secular. The culture around us constantly produces new ideas, philosophies, and values. Many of these

are presented as more authoritative than God's Word. If we are not careful, we can begin to think about God's gifts the same way the world does—as ordinary, common, or optional.

But Scripture teaches us that God has established certain things as sacred. Marriage is sacred. The church is sacred. Human life is sacred. The gospel is sacred. And the Lord's Supper is sacred.

These are not human inventions. They are gifts from God for our good.

Paul's warning reminds us that there are consequences when we prioritize the secular over the sacred.

So why must we learn to discern the difference?

Because every sacred gift points us to God. When we lose sight of the sacred, we lose sight of the Giver.

And how do we discern the sacred from the secular?

We do so by measuring everything against God's Word. We allow Scripture to shape our understanding of life rather than allowing culture to shape our understanding of Scripture.

As we gather around this table, let us remember that the gospel itself is not something we achieve. It is a gift to be received. We do not earn Christ's sacrifice. We receive it by faith. We keep it by the obedience of faith. Communion reminds us of that gift.

As Paul instructed, let each person examine himself. Let us approach this memorial with gratitude, humility, and reverence. Let us recognize the sacred nature of what we are about to do and give thanks to God for the greatest gift ever given; His Son, Jesus Christ.